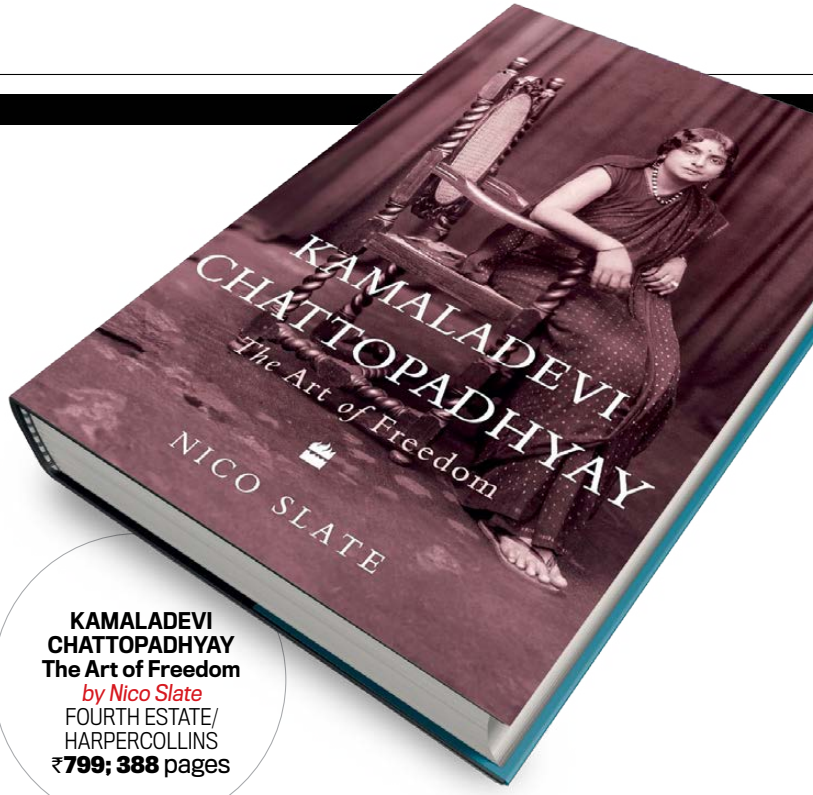
BOOKS

A Life Less Ordinary

A key figure in the freedom movement, post-Independence, **Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay**, devoted herself to the revival of Indian arts and crafts



KAMALADEVI CHATTOPADHYAY
The Art of Freedom
by Nico Slate
FOURTH ESTATE/ HARPERCOLLINS
₹**799; 388** pages

Somewhere in Professor Nico Slate's compelling book on Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay is a story of how, touring South India in her capacity as Chairperson of the All India Handicrafts Board, she learnt of a community of handloom weavers in a remote village about to abandon their craft. Despite the searing May heat, she wrapped a wet towel round her head and drove off in her jeep to meet them. The village was Pochampally; the help and financial and promotional support she gave them turned them into one of the most thriving centres of handloom ikat weaving. The story is typical of Kamaladevi's commitment, passion and practicality, and is only one of many.

It is a tragedy for India that the patriarchal male-centric attitudes of policy-makers in the '50s and '60s prevented

BOOKS

THE TREE PEOPLE

Chandi Prasad Bhatt's autobiography reveals the inner workings of the Chipko movement

Behind the first memorandum of the Chipko movement, Chandi Prasad Bhatt writes, was "a larger collective consciousness or historical context". His autobiography, *Gentle Resistance*, roots the protests against tree-felling in Garhwal in the alienation of its people from their forests.

"The British administration began a systematic process of intervention in our forests." The land settlement of 1823 began "constraining people from the commons and depriving them of their... natural rights." The government of free India did nothing to restore the forests to its citizens, its Forest Department inheriting both ownership and the attitude from the departed colonials.

Born in 1934 to an impoverished Brahmin family in Chamoli district, Chandi Prasad Bhatt lost his father early, and his mother struggled to fund his education. He found a steady job as a bus booking clerk, but the Sarvodaya movement fuelled his idealism. His family now included a wife and child, but on Vinoba's birthday, "I committed myself to a life of social service". He quit his job, consigned the family to renewed poverty, and set out on the Gandhian path.

With the Dasholi Gram Swarajya Sangh (DGSS), Chandi Prasad set up co-operatives to refine pine resin and craft agricultural implements. Government control over forests had "no connection with state socialism, it was naked private capitalism, a conspiracy of big enterprises in collusion with the state". Villagers were refused ash wood for ploughs, but the same